

By **Abhijit Dasgupta**

It takes too many to tango in West Bengal. The promise of sunshine industries and with it, development and jobs by the thousands, now remains only on paper. It's sunset time in West Bengal. After the pullout of Tata's Nano, the scrapping of the DLF township project at Dankuni and the DLF Special Economic Zone (SEZ) at Rajarhat, West Bengal Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya, a crestfallen and dejected man since the elections in May, has more egg on his face. After the worst electoral defeat in 32 years, his time was all but up on September 7, when his Government had to withdraw the much-touted Rs 1,000-crore Kolkata IT Links project with Wipro and Infosys. The information technology giants had to retrace their steps as scandal erupted in the aftermath of the Vedic Village incident on August 23 in which one person died.

The facts of the case are now the stuff of national shame. The Vedic Village country resort at Rajarhat, near which the IT township was to come up is less than an hour's journey from Kolkata and was a favourite haunt for the city's glitterati. On August 24, a local football match here ended in mob violence as a miffed mafioso ordered shooting at jeering villagers to avenge defeat in the game. In a matter of hours, the resort was reduced to ruins. After the incident it came to light that the resort's owner, R.K. Modi, now in jail, was involved in landgrabbing to the extent of 1,500 acres with the help of Gaffar Mollah, a local goon. Gaffar, who was arrested the next morning, named as many as six ministers of the ruling Left Front who were allegedly involved in landgrabbing. Opposition leader Mamata Banerjee expelled three local members of her party for harbouring links with the land grab coterie of the CPI(M).

The chief minister-in-waiting, however, kept uncharacteristically quiet for a full fortnight. She finally held a rally near the village on September 8, calling for a CBI probe and a white paper on all land deals of the state Government. Nobody told

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Death of a BRAND

Buddha's dream of Destination Bengal lies shattered as several CPI(M) leaders come under a cloud in a sordid land grab case



her that Gaffar, immediately after his arrest, had named Ajibul Islam alias Khudey as one of the instigators. Khudey is the brother of Banerjee's party MLA, Arabul Islam. The latter, along with powerful CPI(M) Minister Goutam Deb, had ensured the "peaceful transition" of land from villagers to private investors with the state

Government in between. "I had told Arabul many times not to meet Deb... He has now seen the result for himself. All I can say is that we will not allow anybody to have links with the CPI(M)," said Banerjee. Arabul, however, was also present at Didi's September 8 meeting. He has not been expelled yet.